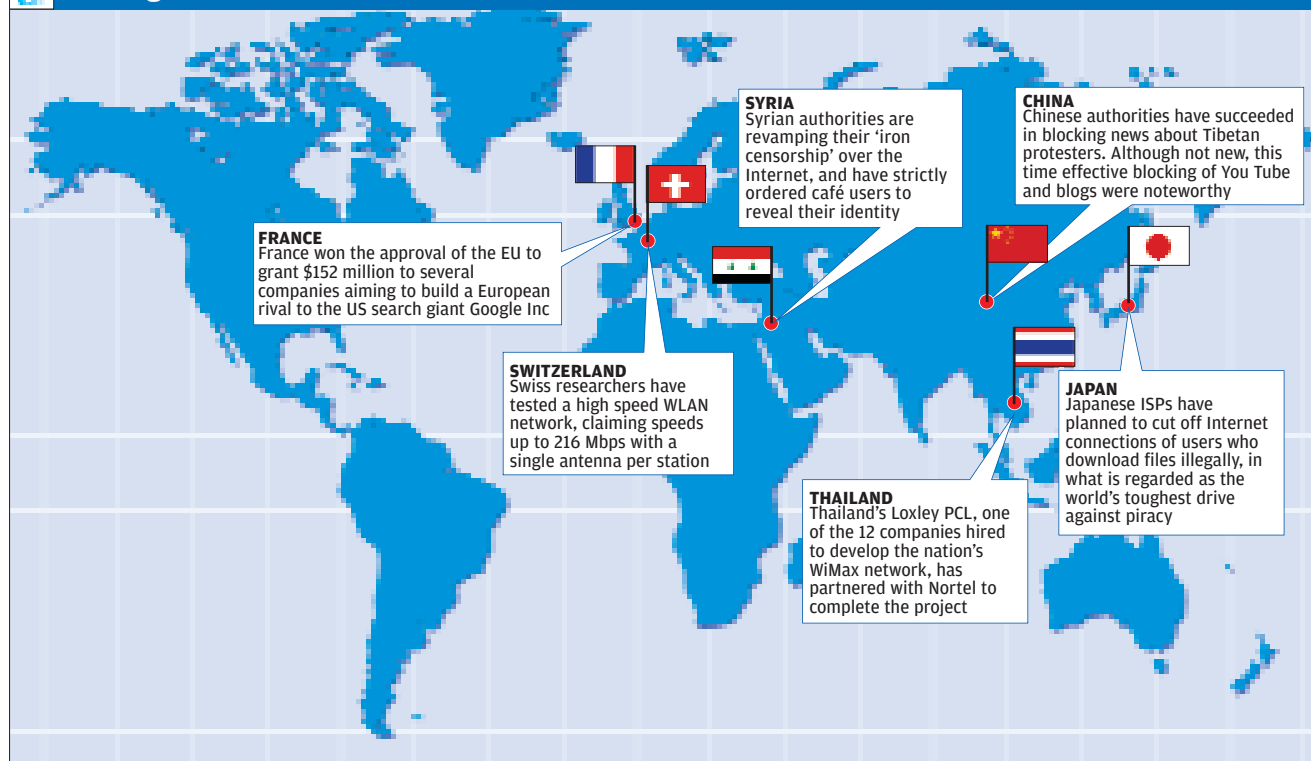




hotspots of Bangalore and Mumbai-IBM's new centre is in Noida and TCS' expansion site in Hyderabad. Among the companies that were analysed were Accenture, BT Global Services, Capgemini, Capita, CSC, EDS, Fujitsu, HP, IBM and Logica.

As salaries of the Indian workforce increase, it seems obvious for the western companies to look for options that provide reduced costs. With an efficient English speaking workforce, Europe seems to be a hot destination. Similarly, close proximity also enhances their say in the outsourcing industry. In fact, the emergence of increased outsourcing to China will be closely watched by the Indian industry for sure.

VIRTUAL BEHAVIOUR

World Of Crime

Some months ago we mentioned *World of Warcraft*, a MMORPG being used to study how

diseases can spread in the real world. Turns out that there are more lessons to be learnt from studying the role playing game universe that are applicable in real life. One of them is how terror works, especially terror cells and the dynamics of crimes.

If you have ever played WoW or heard about it you would know that it has a mind bogglingly diverse set of characters with varied powers and capabilities. The players mimic real life behaviour, both good and bad. The bad side includes crime and terrorism, including bio-terrorism. Now, researchers have zeroed in on this specific trait and have found that studying the in-game behavior can tell them a lot about how bad guys can operate in real life. In fact, the insights gleaned are much more significant than those from AI simulations or mathematical modeling, the traditional tools of choice for analysts when studying phenomena like the

possible spread of diseases like anthrax, or the probability of suicide bombers attacking a particular place.

The crowd behavior, approximating real life after an act of terrorism can also be predicted by observing, for example, what surviving characters do after an explosion in a crowded area.

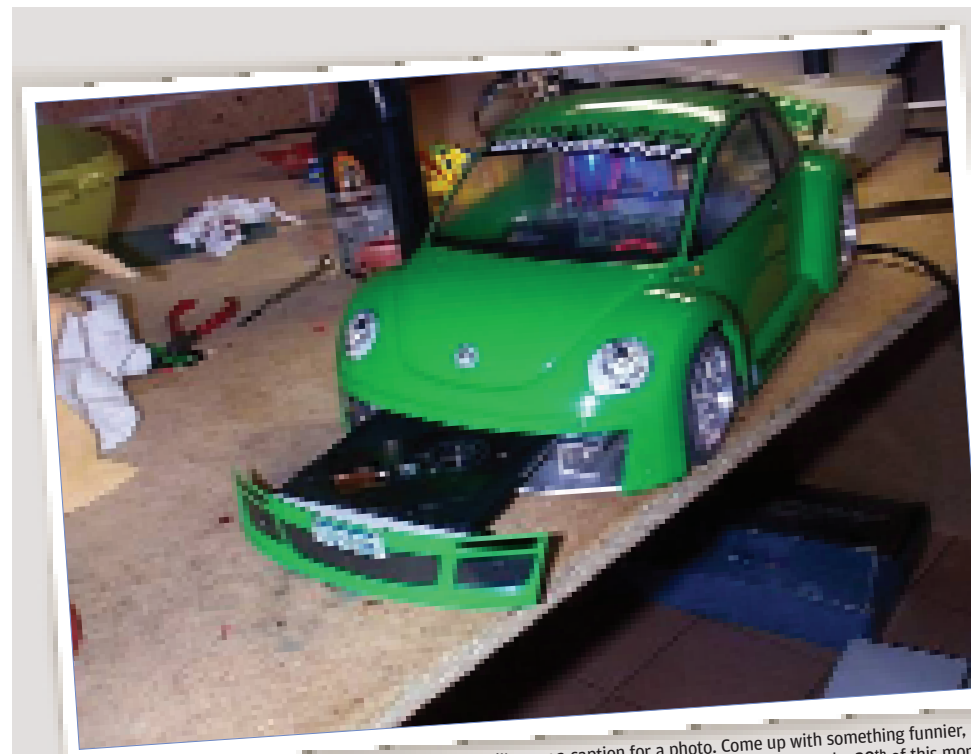
Some researchers however believe that WoW needn't be taken too seriously by spooks. This is because dying in the game is no big deal and you can easily take another new avatar or simply return after a specific period of time. Obviously that's not going to happen in real life and so players tend to take more unrealistic risks. However for all its flaws WoW is the closest researchers have got to real life conditions that can be controlled and they are not letting it go unstudied any time soon. Oh, and they also get the chance to mix business with pleasure, which is another added bonus.

NO MORE LIGHT

Suing All The Way

Light emitting and laser diodes are used in a large number of consumer electronics products from the new fangled Blu-ray drives to the humble CD-ROM drives. They are also used in mobile phones and hand held devices, and even in traffic lights. Companies have been making this stuff for years and have been reasonably clear that all intellectual property related issues have been ironed out. In other words they don't expect someone to pop out and claim royalties.

So this has come as a shock to many companies when the news of a patent infringement lawsuit filed by a retired professor of Columbia University came through. Gertrude Neumark Rothschild, in her complaint which has been accepted by the US International Trade Commission says that a busload of companies have



Photograph Lakshmi Sudheendra

Each month *Digit* will carry a caption for a photo. Come up with something funnier, and beat the *Digit* team at their own game! Entries accepted by the 20th of this month.

been illegally using her patents without paying her any royalty. All total 34 companies, including Sony, Samsung, Nokia, LG, Motorola, Sharp, Hitachi, Sanyo, Sony Ericsson and Toshiba have been named as violators.

ITC is responsible for safeguarding US industries against dumping of goods and takes action against unfair trade practices like patent, trademark and copyright violations. This means that if ITC finds merit in Rothschild's case it can theoretically block the imports of mobile phones, cameras, camcorders etc to the US. We rather think that it won't deprive the American masses of their daily dose, but they might impose a steep fine on all these entities.

This is not the first time the professor has tangled with Big Business. Earlier she had sued Philips and obtained an out of court settlement over this patent. This means that she has built up a pretty bulletproof case and is not

to be taken lightly. The 34 respondents must have already got the message and are presumably brainstorming with their legal teams.

WATCH YOUR PATH

Kerala Mapped

Recently in Kerala, the first Active Web Geographical Information System (GIS) service was launched for public use by the Indian Institute of Information Technology and Management-Kerala. Developed using free and open source software (FOSS) technology, a simplified version of dynamic geographical information is made available to the public.

Log on to www.edugrid.ac.in/webgis, to check out this service. So instead of watching the sky, the users can surf online and find out the forecast for a week in advance. Why would one need an expensive software

or tool when the geospatial information is available on Web browsers? Yes, dynamic weather information and one-week forecast gets updated every three hours.

The available geospatial information could be utilised across several dimensions—from agricultural wellbeing to e-governance projects. Also, thematic maps provide significant information.

As per IIITM-K director K.R. Sriivathsan, "The institute is actively developing Active Web GIS applications for e-governance applications such as community instrumentation for agrarian prosperity, community-driven cultural heritage portals and trade logistics for farm produce". The geospatial information is supposed to benefit many dimensions of the state-right from urban planning to business.

Weather information about the mapped cities / villages of Kerala is integrated with Google Maps. Along with the

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Google Power Tools Bible
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thematic maps of Kerala, the 3D model topography has been developed using VRML (Virtual Reality Markup Language) for the 3D Web GIS.

Besides mapping the state on Google maps and syncing weather information and presenting thematic maps for Kerala, people would surely be expecting a lot more to come. The toughest part is providing dynamically variable forecasting data along with the dynamic geospatial data actively available on the Web browser. However, counting the efforts of the free and open mapping centric Free Map community, this initiative surely has a long way to go. Kudos to the IIITM-K team for Active Web GIS!

SYSTEM FAILURE

Hackermania

Indian government Web sites are under attack. This has prompted the Department of Information Technology to draw plans for better security